The Nature of Buddhi according to Sankhya-Yoga

According to dualism both consciousness and unconsciousness exist independently and eternally as perfect opposites, and yet they somehow are related. As long as they stand isolated and unrelated, there is no experience which arises out of a failure to realize the unrelated nature and the Kevala existence of the Cit. The moment this unrelatedness is realized, there follows the liberation, or the Kaivalya, of the Puruṣa which is the goal of experience. But if, as the sutra says,[1] that experience is failure to distinguish the Sattva and the self which are absolutely unmingled, the question naturally arises how does experience start if originally the conscious Puruṣa is not in contact with the unintelligent Prakṛti and if the two are Atyantāsaṅkirṇa. Vācaspati puts the question thus: How can the self, whose essence is intelligence and whose brightness does not depend upon another, be properly said to illumine that which is inert, and on the other hand, how can the inert *take* illumination?[2]

The answer to the above question and an explanation of the possibility of experience is thought to be provided by a theory of reflection or double reflection, based upon the transparent nature of the Sattva.[3] It is said that the Sattva, although not in combination with the intelligence, but insofar as, being absolutely clear, contains the image of the intelligence; it seems to come in contact with intelligence and so experiences the various things.[4] This is illustrated by the statement, "Buddheh prati samvedi puruṣa," i.e., the Puruṣa, who is not a direct seer and who knows by reflecting the concepts of the Buddhi, is said to be a knower. It is, of course, assumed in order to make the association of the Puruṣa and the Sattva possible, that the Puruṣa is not absolutely different from the Sattva. "Sa buddher nātyantam virūpah."[5] The Puruṣa is not absolutely different from the Buddhi for though pure, it sees the ideas after they have come into the mind. It cognizes the phenom-